

Republics of Hate

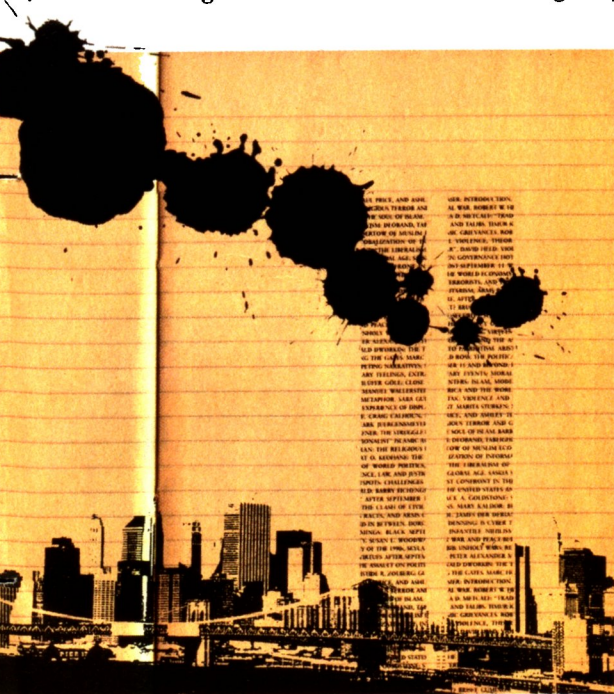
Change. You think it was Barack Obama who gave the word a historical resonance? It happened long before he turned the oldest cliché in politics into a movement. It happened eight years ago on that morning in Manhattan, when the looming towers of freedom and aspiration melted down in flames of hate. As *Le Monde* famously said in an editorial, we were all American that day—of course, if we were not the paying guests of Mullah Omar at Tora Bora. It changed everything. It shattered the cozy assumptions of a post-Wall world where the Socialist New Man was a comic strip hero in the Hermit Kingdom or a fading parody of a revolutionary in Havana—or a stentorian anti-imperialist in Venezuela desperate for a role in Mario Vargas Llosa's next novel. (The People's Republic was a class apart, as the mandarins were not strictly living by the Book.) It brought Evil out of its religious context and placed it at the vital centre of geopolitics. It set the stage for the globalisation of fear. It gave jihad its Che cult: elsewhere in the craggy remoteness of Afghanistan, the bearded action hero of jihad, accessorised by a Kalashnikov, with a gaze as piercing as his words of death and retribution, looked straight into the video camera. It was not exactly a clash of civilisations; it was more a rage against civilisation. Most dramatically it changed the incumbent at the Oval Office, till then every left liberal's favourite fool. He became a war president with a moral agenda. He fought two wars in the name of freedom. One of them became fatally unpopular and in the last flickering embers of the struggle was born Hope, also known as Obama. In the aftermath, we all changed, we all spoke differently, and we all sacrificed a part of our freedom.

Eight years on, where has 9/11 brought us? Iraq is no longer the war that America wants to fight. Bush succeeded in liberating Iraqis from Saddam Hussein. Obama would

like to claim success in liberating America from Mesopotamia. Priorities have changed; and so has the arena of the just war. Afghanistan, though, is proving to be a minor variation on Vietnam; the persistence of the enemy is testing the combined powers of Britain and America and there is no end in sight. Al Qaeda, as "the base" of jihad, may have become dysfunctional; and Osama, the troglodyte of radical Islam, may have realised the limitations of videotapes. The terror is no longer underground; it's official, as in Tehran, where the ghost of the Great Islamic Revolution is seeking legitimacy in the blood of the martyr. Or as in Pakistan, where jihad is being sustained by state subsidy. The afterglow of 9/11 only illuminates the new Republics of Hate.



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SAURABH SINGH

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Vice-Admiral G. M. Hiranandani, former vice-chief of naval staff. He was the flag officer commanding in chief of Southern Naval Command at Kochi from 1985-87. He commissioned the navy's first guided missile destroyer *INS Rajput* in 1980.

DIED: Harcharan Singh Brar, former chief minister of Punjab



and erstwhile governor of Haryana and Orissa. He was 87.

DIED: Economist B.M. Bhatia, 94. He wrote extensively on the agrarian situation in India and worked on UN committees.

NAMED: Lt-General P. C. Bhardwaj as the next vice-chief of army staff, bypassing Lt-General V. K. Singh, the seniormost three-star general. This is the first time that the seniormost officer has been bypassed.

